

THE ARTS

Moving out of the canvas, art became graffiti and billboards; leaving the confines of an auditorium, it became street theatre and music concerts; and shifting from cinemascope, art became advertisements and a high-end fashion industry. The meaning of art has changed with the times. The last decade has made it more democratic and secular. "It has stepped out of the hallowed sanctuaries of the elite and come onto the streets where its effects can be felt and enjoyed by the common man," says art historian Yashodhara Dalmia. Just as Subhashis Gangopadhyay, who started a theatre troupe in Kolkata, Anyodesh, that works with the blind or Vijaynath Shenoy, who has reconstructed heritage homes at his expense, or even Father Prashant Madtha, who has reconstructed the Kannada language, art has been re-crafted by a resurgent India to serve society.

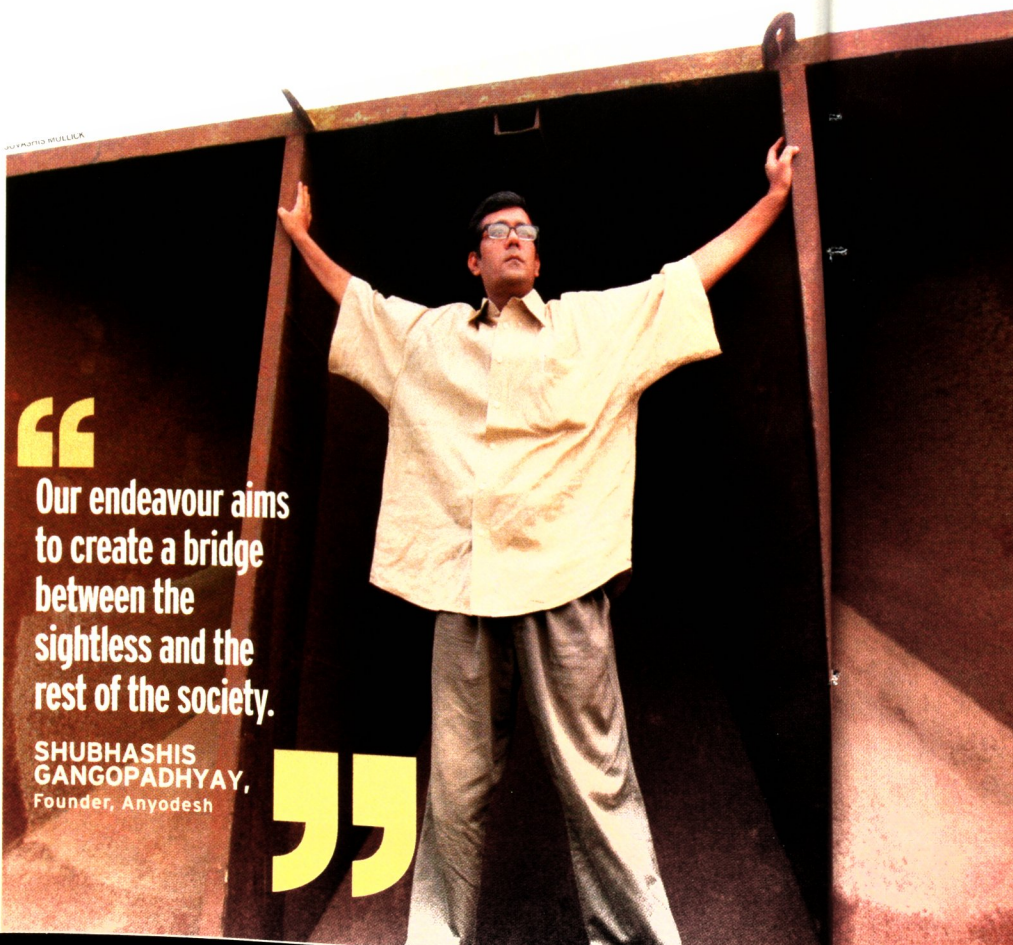
■ By Sudip Bandyopadhyay

The curtains have been pulled back. Flooded by a beam of light, the stage is about to host *Raktokorobi*, Red Oleanders, a play written by Rabindranath Tagore. The performers, members of Anyodesh (another land), a theatre troupe from Kolkata led by Shubhashis Gangopadhyay, may be blind, but they face the world with a rare confidence

despite being doubly diminished by poverty.

Gangopadhyay saw enormous potential in the sightless when he first met some visually-impaired artistes at a theatre workshop in Kolkata's Behala Blind School in 1994. Two years later, he, who had been a member of the Nandikar theatre group for a decade, founded The Blind Opera along with his theatre-loving friends Asok Pramanik, Debashish Choudhury and Prasanta Chattopadhyay. After another decade of successes, in 2006,

Gangopadhyay launched another venture, an endeavour for sightless women, and Anyodesh came into being under the supervision of The Blind Opera. After its grand success, some of his comrades wanted to make the group, The Blind Opera, a mainstream theatre troupe. This was no less than an ideological catastrophe for Gangopadhyay and he sidelined the working of Anyodesh from the Opera. The troupe specialises in street drama, which means low production and instant audience



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Our endeavour aims to create a bridge between the sightless and the rest of the society.

SHUBHASHIS GANGOPADHYAY,
Founder, Anyodesh

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**vision
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✱ **Shubhashis Gangopadhyay**

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on stage

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people across...
globe who are...
over 15 mil...
are from India